

reflections. Can it be that India, at this high moment in its history, is forgetting its own narrative of openness and beginning to bring down the shutters? Can it be that those who would close the universe are gaining the ascendancy over those who would open it?

Let me just be clear about this: the exile of M.F. Husain, his fears for his safety in his beloved homeland, the scurrilous cases brought against him, the weakness of the government response, and his decision to accept Qatari citizenship and thus cease to be an Indian national—these things are shameful, and Husain's plight is a disgrace. That Husain is building a museum abroad to house his own personal collection, so that masterworks which are a part of this country's artistic narrative will be lost to India: that is another aspect of the tragedy. Ugliest of all is the language being used against Husain, which one can find

growing volubility is immensely disturbing. It is deeply distressing to find so much volcanic hatred bubbling so near to the surface of everyday life.

If there is anything to add to this much-debated issue, I think it may be this: that, as in the case of the Danish cartoons (although Husain's work far outranks those scribbles), we should understand that there are two separate issues here. The first issue may be expressed thus: what do we think of Husain's paintings of Hindu goddesses? Do we like or dislike them? Are we given aesthetic pleasure or deep offence by them? And even: should they be publicly exhibited or not?

To these questions there can be, and there plainly are, many different answers. It is plain that the work is disliked as well as liked, that it gives offence as well as pleasure, and it is perfectly proper that people voice their responses, whatever those may be. This is the risk of art: you offer the

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SALMAN RUSHDIE
(LEFT) WITH SESSION
CHAIRPERSON
AROON PURIE

"I WAS BORN INTO A HOUSE OF ARGUMENT AND DEBATE, RAISED IN THE BELIEF THAT OPEN DISAGREEMENT IS THE BEST GUARANTEE OF AN OPEN SOCIETY."

SALMAN RUSHDIE

today all over the Internet, in comments attached to newspaper reportage and sometimes—too often—in press reportage and commentary as well.

This is a language so distasteful that I do not want to quote it verbatim. A grand old man is jeered at for being old. A man painting from the depths of his soul is accused of immoral pornography. An artist who has given decades of his life to the imagination is dismissed as worthless. His self-imposed exile is called cowardice, and to his change of nationality many say, "good riddance". These voices do not emanate from the India I love but from another, emerging, openly philistine, proudly communalist India whose

products of your imagination to the public's scrutiny, and the public will respond as it will. If the respond be divided, or hostile, so be it. That is sometimes the price of doing the work. Even on the last question—should the work be exhibited?—which, in the case of the Danish cartoons, was the question of whether the cartoons should be published, there will inevitably be strong feelings on both sides, yes and no. I return to my earlier point about the nature of freedom: freedom is an argument. And sometimes you lose it. There can be no objection to people expressing vehement feelings on this issue, though there can and should be an objection to the ugliness of their language. I would go so far as to suggest that